L[INK]: Turning Campus Moments into Chance Encounters with Strangers

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Domain

Serendipitous connections on campus. To foster genuine, low-pressure encounters between university students who might otherwise never cross paths.

Prior Attempts

1. **Next2You (Paasovaara et al., 2016)**
   - A concept app to spark face-to-face interaction between nearby strangers.
   - Insight: progressive disclosure lowers the social risk of the first interaction.
   - Applied: drawing is the first step, and users are anonymous by default.
2. **Sketching with Strangers (Åkerman et al., 2010)**
   - Two linked tables in nightclubs let strangers connect through shared drawings.
   - Insight: people want to connect with strangers, so give them a safe, low-effort way to act.
   - Applied: two linked stations in separate locations, with location-tied prompts.

Defining the Problem Space

Problem: Students share campus every day but rarely have a reason to talk.
Opportunity: turn everyday waiting time into low-stakes, chance connections.
Target audience: UQ students (18+) with pockets of downtime between classes who want playful, low-pressure connection without commitment.

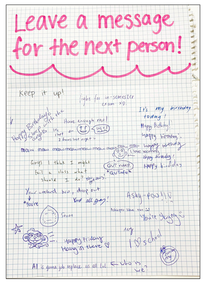
Links to Social and Mobile Computing

Social
- Shared object: tablets give strangers a common focus.
- Shared manipulation: strokes change the drawing.
- Shared space: others are waiting nearby.
- Traces: the canvas shows somebody was here before.
- Awareness: live strokes make a remote stranger perceptible.
- Scaffolding: turns structure the interaction.

Mobile
- Location-aware: tablets sit in one place and detect when two are active.
- Context-aware: prompts fit the place, like “Any food cravings today?”
- Transient: short, opportunistic interactions.
- Public/private: anonymous by default, with control over what you reveal.

Research, Interviews & Testing

Probes



Interviews

“There aren’t enough excuses to actually talk to people… if there was something that gave people a proper reason to start talking, more people would actually go for it.”

“I wish it was less weird… making it less weird would be kind of cool.”

Students wanted a reason to connect with others, not just a way to meet people. We moved away from networking through shared interests and toward a low-stakes shared activity.

> “If you really want to interact with a random stranger, I don’t see another medium that you can do that in.”

Secondary Interviews:

“[Forced icebreakers] get you talking to people but it’s not exactly a connection that’s maintained.”

“[Shared activities are] way less awkward than if we’d just been standing around trying to make small talk.”

“It would be really fun if you’re constantly going past it…to see how people are interpreting what you’ve done and expanding on it”.

The idea of a shared activity resonated with our participants more, so we narrowed our concept to the message trail.

“I wouldn’t deliberately go up there and check, but if I’m passing on the way, it would be nice to see it.”

“I would never want to vandalise anything… The only thing I could think of is leaving something that’s a digital trace.”

“It feels less lonely than just writing something and not knowing if anyone will ever see it. Like there’s an audience.”

Test Sessions

“Whenever I’m waiting for food to heat up, I’m usually just on my phone or talking to a friend… if I saw this, I’d definitely go check it out.”

“It’s really cool to think that someone I don’t know, and probably never will know, is on the other side doing stuff.”

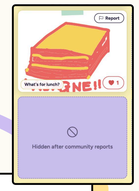
“I think anonymous is fun, yeah, just random people. I feel like there’s more pressure putting your identity out there.”

“I think it was fun, kind of a cute little interaction. You don’t know who it is, but you know you’re both doing this at the same time.”

“No one reads the instructions.”

Ethical Implications

- **Consent and control:** live drawing starts suddenly, so a user could feel trapped. Our action: an exit button at any point.
- **Pressure to reveal identity:** webcams or photos raise safety and privacy concerns. Our action: emoji reactions let users respond without revealing who they are.
- **Misuse of the shared canvas:** an open, anonymous canvas can carry harassment or slurs. Our action: a one-tap report button hides flagged drawings.



Real-World Testing





How to Use L[INK]

1 Notice



A tablet at the printer or microwave shows a prompt and other’s drawings.

2 Contribute



Draw a response while you wait

3 Link Up



If both tablets are active at the same time, opportunity to colaborate!

4 Collaborate



Take turns on one shared prompt and compliment your partner

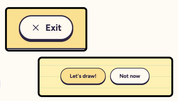
5 Save



Keep a memento of your interaction with a stranger

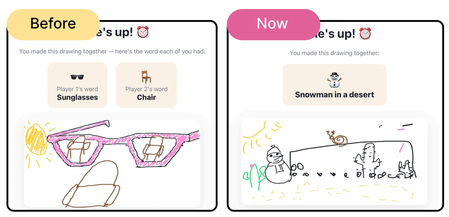
> “It’s definitely a lot more fun knowing there are other live people actually doing stuff with me.”

> “There’s like no other way to exit or leave right? You just have to play.”

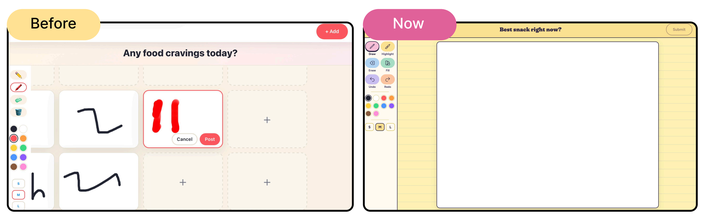


Prototype Iterations

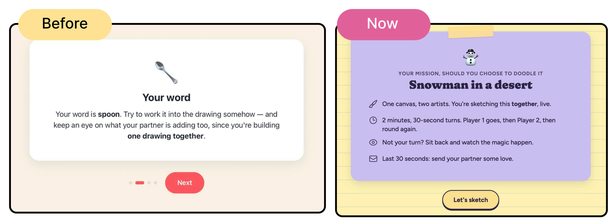
Separate prompts → Shared prompt



Small, individualised canvas → expanded canvas



Multiple instruction cards → Single instruction card



Future Opportunities

> “A voice chat could be kind of cool, actually…”

- **Short term:** alert people near a tablet. Progressive reveal: emojis now, then opt-in voice chat, then a mutual option to meet. Relay drawing for missed connections.
- **Long term:** more tablets at waiting spots, with a public map or time-lapse. Themed prompts tied to the calendar, like O-Week. Smarter moderation: automatic screening plus reports.



